

Grown-up's Playbook: The Long Winter's Night

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

The Long Winter's Night: Rules for the Grown-Up

New to this? Read the Guide for the Grown-Up first. It explains the whole idea in two pages and you will never need it again.

You are the Game Master, which here means a few small jobs at once: storyteller, gentle referee, the children's biggest fan, and a fellow adventurer who plays along. This is a cooperative game for two or more who play together, a grown-up and one or more children, all on the same side. Nobody competes, and nobody loses. This is a braver tale than some, set on a cold and shadowy winter's night, but cleverness and kindness still win every time, and no one is ever truly hurt.

Setting up

- Print the map. Each player puts a small figure on the Start, the Hearth Hall.
- This world has no magic. Instead each hero leans on one of three qualities: **Wit** (clever thinking), **Courage** (a steady heart in the dark), or **Heart** (caring for others). On the hero sheet, where it says magic, let each child write the quality they like best. Two different qualities work best together.
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). They are spent and refilled during play.
- Set out three props if you can: a glowing token or red brick for the Everwarm Ember, a ball of string or red wool for the red yarn, and a small cake or token for the honey bun. Anything can be anything.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

Difficulty bands, not dice

Challenges never call for a particular die. Each one has a band: **Easy**, **Normal**, or **Hard**. When the players try something, look up the band on the kit's dice-band table, which tells you the number to meet or beat with whatever dice your family owns. Every challenge can be played with a single ordinary die.

The golden rule: here nobody loses

A failed roll is never a defeat. It is a detour to a different route. When a roll does not meet the band, the players always have a way through:

- **Spend an energy star** to gather themselves and try the idea again, or
- **Join two qualities** once per stop to pass with no roll at all (Wit and Heart together, say, or Courage and Wit).

Energy stars come back when the players move on to the next stop, and when they help each other. Nobody can ever run dry for long, and nobody is ever stuck on the long night.

Helping each other: the Helping Hand

At any moment one player may help another instead of acting alone. When they do, make the help roll: on a success the challenge is passed for the pair, even if the first roll missed.

Helping is generous, so reward it; it also tops up an energy star. On the longest night, no hero stands alone in the cold.

The Twist of Fate

At each stop, once, the players may roll for a twist and you read out the matching line. Use whichever die the dice-band table gives you for this; with a single ordinary die, read the line

that matches the number rolled.

Roll	Twist of Fate
1	Nori the Tomte pops up in his red cap and gives you one free hint.
2	You find a burst of warmth in your chest, and take back one energy star.
3	A following wind off the fjord, and the next challenge is Easy.
4	The Two Ravens, Thought and Memory, fly over and nod kindly. All is well.
5	A lucky knot in the red yarn: keep one roll to use again later.
6	The Everwarm Ember flares bright, and for a moment everyone feels brave.

How it ends

The Lonely Frost Giant on the road is the "foe", but he is no villain. He is a giant of pale ice who has simply been cold and lonely too long, and there is no fight in him to win. The tale is won not by beating him but by befriending him: a shared honey bun, a kind question, a place by the ember. He then comes along and crosses the Rainbow Bridge with the heroes, and together they relight the world's warmth at the high hall as dawn breaks. Let the kindness land; it is the whole point. See the puzzles page for the three challenges and their solutions.

The Long Winter's Night: Puzzles and Solutions

For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward cleverness and kindness over the "right" answer.

Stop 1: The Frozen Fjord (Normal)

The challenge. The heroes must cross the Frozen Fjord, a wide sheet of ice that groans and creaks underfoot. The danger is not a monster but the ice itself, which will not take a heavy, hasty crowd all at once.

Intended solution. This is a Spatial and Logic moment. The clever, kind move is to **spread out** so their weight is shared, **step gently** so they treat the ice kindly, and **cross together holding hands** so no one is left behind. Laying the **red yarn** down as a guide line, or testing the way ahead carefully, works just as well.

Fallback. If the children are unsure, have the **Two Ravens** wheel overhead and "caw" the heroes into a careful, spread-out line, or let them spend an energy star to steady their footing. Crossing slowly and gently always works, and tops up an energy star.

Stop 2: The Lonely Frost Giant (Hard, then no roll)

The challenge. A huge giant of pale blue ice sits in the road with his arms folded. He looks fearsome, and the players may feel this is a fight. It is not.

Intended solution. This is a Heart and Courage moment. The giant is simply cold and lonely; nobody ever stops to speak with him. Any genuine kindness works: sharing the **warm honey bun**, asking his name, offering him a place by the **Everwarm Ember**, telling him he need not be alone. When the children are kind, his icy face warms into a smile, he becomes their friend, and he comes along with them. There is no roll to beat him, because there is no beating him; there is only befriending him.

Fallback. If the children freeze, or want to "win" by force, have the giant shiver and ask, very quietly, "Are you cold and lonely too?" A single warm word melts him. The kindness is the whole challenge, and it cannot be failed.

Stop 3: The Rainbow Bridge (Normal)

The challenge. The shimmering Rainbow Bridge rises to the high halls, and it holds firm only for those who cross with a kind and honest heart. The heroes must cross, carrying the ember, and reach the high hall to relight the world's warmth.

Intended solution. This is a Heart and Wit moment. Because the heroes carry the **Everwarm Ember** and now travel with the **Lonely Frost Giant** as a friend, their hearts are exactly what the bridge is looking for. Crossing honestly and gently, keeping their new friend beside them, the bridge brightens and holds. At the top they lift the ember and the world's warmth catches light again.

Fallback. If they hesitate at the edge, have the bridge glow a little warmer with each kind word they say, so a single honest "we came to bring the warmth back" lights the way across. The bridge always holds for these heroes; their hearts have already earned it.

The ending

There is no battle and no loser. When the ember is lifted at the high hall, every hearth-fire relights down the valley, every amber window glows again, and the longest night ends in dawn and colour. The **Aurora Spirits** dance overhead, the **Lonely Frost Giant** has friends at last, and **Freya the Kind** smiles down from the high halls. The heroes have won the only way

anyone wins here, by being clever, brave, and kind.

Wits and Wonder

Grown-up's Playbook

<https://github.com/agigante80/wits-and-wonder>

Content licence: CC BY-SA 4.0 (<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0/>)

Version 1.4, updated 2026-06-04, en-GB



Scan for the latest version

Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.